Orthopaedics Service Line Handbook

MERIDIAN HEALTH PARTNERS ## OPERATIONS POLICY MANUAL: ORTHOPAEDICS SERVICE LINE Document ID: MHP-POL-ORTH-014 Effective Date: 14 January 2025 Applies To: All 14 Meridian Health Partners outpatient sites, Department of Orthopaedics, Patient Access Center, and Billing Services Operations Policy Lead: Dr. Aris Thorne, MD, MHA Approved By: Meridian Clinical Governance Board

1. PURPOSE AND SCOPE This document establishes the operational parameters, clinical inclusion and exclusion boundaries, scheduling durations, patient preparation protocols, insurance alignment, and service-level commitments for the Orthopaedics department across all 14 Meridian Health Partners outpatient facilities.

2. CONDITIONS ACCEPTED AND EXPLICITLY NOT ACCEPTED

2.1 Accepted Conditions The Orthopaedics department accepts adult and adolescent patients (ages 14 and older) presenting with the following musculoskeletal conditions: 1. Degenerative joint disease of the knee, hip, and shoulder. 2. Acute non-surgical sports injuries (ligamentous sprains, meniscal tears, tendinopathies). 3. Chronic overuse syndromes and soft tissue impingements. 4. Post-operative follow-up care for procedures performed within the Meridian network or by approved external surgeons holding Meridian affiliate privileges. 5. Simple stable fractures cleared from emergency departments for outpatient management.

2.2 Explicitly Not Accepted Conditions The following clinical presentations are excluded from the Orthopaedics department schedule and must be redirected to appropriate emergency or specialized tertiary care facilities: 1. Acute open fractures, active joint infections (septic arthritis), and acute compartment syndrome. These require immediate transfer to a Level 1 or Level 2 trauma center emergency department. 2. Pediatric patients under the age of 14 years. These must be referred to the Valley Children's Pediatric Orthopaedic Network. 3. Active spinal cord injuries, acute vertebral compression fractures with neurological deficit, and complex spinal deformities. These fall under the exclusive purview of the Neurosurgery and Spine Service Line (Policy MHP-POL-NSG-003). 4. Oncologic bone lesions and primary musculoskeletal sarcomas. These require direct referral to the Horizon Cancer Institute Sarcoma Center.

3. APPOINTMENT DURATION AND SCHEDULING TIMEFRAMES

3.1 Consultation and Follow-Up Slots Scheduling templates across all 14 sites must adhere strictly to the following appointment durations: * Initial New Patient Consultation: Exactly 40 minutes allocated per slot. * Routine Follow-Up Visit: Exactly 20 minutes allocated per slot. * Post-Operative Evaluation: Exactly 20 minutes allocated per slot. * In-Office Procedure (e.g., intra-articular injection): Exactly 30 minutes allocated per slot.

4. PATIENT PREPARATION INSTRUCTIONS

The Patient Access Center and automated reminder system must deliver the following mandatory preparation instructions to all scheduled orthopaedic patients:

1. Imaging and Records: Patients must bring physical films or a secure digital DICOM CD of all relevant diagnostic imaging (X-rays, MRI, CT scans) performed outside the Meridian network, along with corresponding radiology reports. Failure to provide imaging completed within the preceding 180 days may result in appointment rescheduling.
2. Attire: Patients presenting for lower extremity evaluations must wear loose-fitting shorts or trousers that can be rolled above the knee. Patients presenting for upper extremity evaluations must wear sleeveless or loose short-sleeve garments.
3. Medication Reconciliation: Patients must bring a complete, physical list of all current prescription medications, over-the-counter drugs, and herbal supplements.
4. Arrival Window: Patients must check in at the reception desk exactly 20 minutes prior to their scheduled appointment time to complete pre-visit intake questionnaires and vital sign recording.

5. INSURANCE COVERAGE BY MERIDIAN PLAN TIER

Orthopaedic procedures and consultations are governed by the four Meridian health plan tiers as detailed below:

Procedure / Service Category	Meridian Access Plan (Tier 1)	Meridian Choice Plan (Tier 2)	Meridian Premier Plan (Tier 3)	Meridian Executive Plan (Tier 4)
Initial & Follow-Up Consultations	Covered ($30 copay)	Covered ($20 copay)	Covered ($10 copay)	Covered ($0 copay)
Diagnostic Imaging (X-Ray, MRI)	Covered ($50 copay)	Covered ($30 copay)	Covered ($10 copay)	Fully Covered ($0)
In-Office Injections (Hyaluronic Acid/Corticosteroid)	Covered with prior auth ($75 copay)	Covered ($40 copay)	Covered ($15 copay)	Fully Covered ($0)
Outpatient Arthroscopic Surgeries	Covered (20% coinsurance after deductible)	Covered (15% coinsurance after deductible)	Covered (10% coinsurance; $500 cap)	Fully Covered ($0)
Named Exception: Robotic-Assisted Joint Arthroplasty	Not Covered	Covered with prior auth (20% coinsurance)	Fully Covered ($0 copay)	Fully Covered ($0 copay)

6. REFERRAL TURNAROUND COMMITMENT

6.1 Processing SLA The Orthopaedics department commits to a strict internal turnaround time for all incoming provider-to-provider referrals: 1. Standard Referrals: All routine referrals submitted via the Meridian electronic health record must be reviewed, triaged, and scheduled (or formally declined with clinical rationale) within 48 business hours of receipt. 2. Urgent Referrals: Referrals marked as urgent by the originating primary care provider (e.g., acute meniscal lock, unstable localized trauma) must be triaged and contacted for scheduling within 8 business hours of receipt. 3. Escalation Protocol: Any referral remaining unprocessed past 72 business hours automatically flags to the regional practice manager, Brenda Vance, for immediate allocation.